

CHAPTER 7

PLANNING

Without a plan, reaching your goals tends to be a hit-or-miss proposition, and time is easily wasted. Without a plan, you may find yourself reacting to the demands of others rather than focusing on your own goals. Without a plan, you will miss the benefits that come from using effective planning skills. Before considering the benefits of effective planning, perform the self-audit on the next page, and identify your strengths and areas for improvement with regard to planning.

The benefits of effective planning are many. For one, planning leads to higher productivity. Because a plan identifies what needs to be done, by when, and by whom, employees understand their role in accomplishing a specific goal. Arguments over responsibilities, resources, and work schedules diminish. As a result, there are fewer interruptions—employees have the information they need to do their jobs, so they can leave you alone to do yours.

There is also an improved use of resources. With employees understanding their part in reaching a goal, there is less overlap of effort and less time spent in confusion. Consequently, more time and energy are applied to getting results. A fourth benefit is the ability to delegate effectively. With a plan in place to reach your goals, you can identify the tasks to be delegated and the people who can complete them.

It is likely that your employees will enjoy improved morale as a result of your improved planning. Employees appreciate being given a focus, and they appreciate contributing to significant results. Too often, a lack of planning leads to frequent crisis management. And crisis management, with its frantic nature, often contributes to a mismanagement of resources including employees, which leads to a decline in morale. But, in contrast, better planning leads to improved quality. The quality problems that come from rushed or incomplete work are avoided. Systematic planning also helps to identify deviations from what should be occurring, so that you can make corrections before a crisis occurs.

PLANNING SELF-AUDIT

1. How many hours do you spend planning your daily, weekly, or monthly work? Daily _____ Weekly _____ Monthly _____
2. Do you have a plan for reaching your goals? Yes ____ No ____
3. How many hours are spent managing crises on a daily basis? _____
4. Could some of these crises be averted with planning? Yes ____ No ____

5. Do you have plans or policies to manage the most frequent concerns and tasks in your department? Yes _____ No _____
6. Do you set clear goals for yourself? For your employees? (Self) Yes _____ No _____ (Employees) Yes _____ No _____
7. Do you encourage the use of a systematic planning process when trying to reach significant goals? Yes _____ No _____
8. Do you remember to evaluate your plan in terms of what can go wrong? Yes _____ No _____
9. Do you have the skills to plan effectively? Yes _____ No _____

Take a moment to consider your current work situation. What are three benefits of planning that could accrue to you?

1.

2.

3.

PLANNING IS A MANAGEMENT SKILL

Many managers find they become less reactive and more proactive as they increasingly practice effective planning. Instead of embracing a management style that reacts to the crises of the day, planners plan their tomorrows. In the shift from a reactive to a proactive stance, managers find that the number of brushfires they must fight decreases. They anticipate problems and have a plan in place to handle them calmly and systematically.

Planning will help you identify the steps necessary for reaching your goals. In contrast, failing to plan can lead to the perception that you are an ineffective manager. You'll attain fewer results and waste resources because of a lack of planning.

Additionally, conflicts among employees increase because of the confusion that surrounds their jobs. Who is supposed to do what? By when? And for what reason? These are the questions you hear when employees do not have a plan to guide them.

Two additional problems that occur when there isn't sufficient planning are the increased probability of accidents and higher production costs. Inadequate staffing, tight schedules, a lack of resources, and increased time pressures contribute to that higher risk environment. And higher production costs accrue as a result of reduced output, lower morale, and higher stress levels.

Many managers claim that they have no time to plan. Day-today events and activities push regular planning into the background. And it's true that fighting brushfires takes time and energy away from fire prevention. However, planning saves time in the long run. Numerous experiments have been made to measure the value of planning. One group applies more time to planning, while a second group goes about business as usual. Repeatedly, the planned work is completed more quickly and with higher-quality results.

Front-line supervisors in a paper mill repeatedly stated that their workload was overwhelming, and that they had no time for planning. The classic response was, "We're too busy fighting fires to plan." Challenged to spend just twenty minutes a day planning, several of the supervisors agreed to give it a try. Within four weeks, those who planned their days found that they were facing fewer production crises and fewer employee conflicts. They also reported feeling more confident about their ability to do their job.

KEY PLANNING STEPS

Six basic questions frame the planning process: Who? What? When? Where? Why? How? Answering these six questions is essential to effective planning. *Who* determines responsibility. It identifies the person responsible for completing each part of the plan. Knowing this enhances teamwork and personal accountability for accomplishing tasks. *What* establishes the goal and details the results and standards to be met. For example, "Make six widgets" is a goal. But natural questions are, "Can you be more specific?" and "How long do we have to make them?" If you can be more specific, say so. "Make six four-sided blue widgets within the next seven days" is a focused goal. The more specific your goal, the more specific your plan can be. And the clarity of your plan helps diminish confusion, increase confidence, and contribute to the effective use of resources.

When marks the time frame for the plan's beginning and end, as well as providing scheduled progress checks along the way. So for each step, identify the time allotted for completing that step. *Where* identifies the place for carrying out the steps of the plan. *How* defines the steps to be completed, and within each step, clarifies the procedures to be used. Finally, *why* provides the personal motivation of those involved to work the plan and to reach the goal. Remember that motivation differs depending on the people involved. Take the time to identify what motivates each of your employees to accomplish a particular goal, and then encourage them to use that information.

ENSURING A FAIL-SAFE PLAN

There are a few more ways you can maximize the benefits of your plan. One is to avoid making assumptions. Be specific—anticipate and answer questions, and document your plan and your progress. Another is to ensure that you look for potential problems in your plan. Parts of your plan are apt to be vulnerable, and these vulnerabilities could disrupt the success

of your plan and jeopardize your ability to reach the goal.

For example, initiating something new creates a vulnerability. If you are doing something for the first time, all the kinks may not have been worked out. Tight deadlines create a vulnerable situation, and so do activities controlled by more than one person. In each situation, consider how you can minimize the potential difficulty.

A third suggestion is to ensure that you communicate with people whose cooperation is essential for the success of the plan. And these people sometimes are different from those who are responsible for carrying out the plan. You will also want to emphasize follow-up and follow-through. Your attention to detail will ensure that nothing falls between the cracks.

Finally, you need to establish a fair method for providing specific feedback to those working the plan, so that praise is given when warranted and correction is provided as needed.